Ready for machine-speed attackers?

Trinidad and Tobago's banks and financial institutions in the age of AI-enabled hacking

Economic research | Shane Dante Bideshi | 28 October 2026, revised and extended 29 October 2026

Executive assessment

Between 2024 and 2026, hacking changed. At first, attackers used AI as an assistant. Now AI agents can carry out most of an intrusion while a human supervises. In 2025, a group assessed as Chinese state-sponsored used an AI coding agent to perform an estimated 80-90% of an espionage campaign against about 30 organisations, financial institutions among them. In September 2026, a security vendor reported that one operator, relying mainly on inexpensive Chinese open-weight models with a US model coordinating them, compromised at least 27 online retailers to varying degrees in five days, at an average cost of about US$25 per target scanned. In October 2026, South Korea's financial regulator said attacks suspected of being driven by AI agents had hit 16 financial firms.

Chinese and other open-weight models do not matter because they are the strongest hacking tools. They are not. Most AI-assisted intrusions documented so far used closed US models, whose developers detected and stopped them, usually after the fact. Government evaluators place the best open-weight models roughly four to eight months behind leading US models on cyber tasks. They matter because anyone can download them, strip out their safety controls cheaply and run them where no AI company can monitor or stop them. US and UK evaluators found that one such model, once given initial network access, can autonomously attack "small, weakly defended and vulnerable enterprise systems". **Parts of a small country's financial system may fit that description**, particularly smaller credit unions, brokers and vendors with few security staff, although no public data measure how exposed Trinidad and Tobago's internet-facing systems are.

The newest attacks show where this is heading. In the last two weeks of October 2026:

- The US Federal Election Commission took its campaign-finance filing systems offline for about two days after "a bad actor" tried to breach them, a week before the midterm elections.
- Six Japanese banks, including Resona Bank, disclosed that customers' email addresses had leaked, or may have leaked, through a breach at Ymirlink, an email-delivery company used by the banks or their app provider.
- Attackers broke into a GMO Internet hosted-desktop service used by currency traders. Customers reported unauthorised trades, and the attackers demanded about ¥8 billion (about US$50 million).

None of these has been linked to AI. Separately, in October Microsoft reported a China-aligned group using an AI agent framework that, in several cases, reached privileged access within three hours. In September, GreyNoise documented "hundreds of AI agents" compromising 440 servers at 395 organisations in 48 countries in about 45 hours.

AI capability is accelerating, and agent "swarms" are real. The length of task that frontier models can complete has been doubling roughly every four to five months, and freely downloadable models trail the frontier by four to seven months. In June 2026 the heads of the Five Eyes cyber agencies warned: "The timeline is not years, it is months." Swarms are not unstoppable, however. In the largest documented case, attackers reached full network control at only 12 of 440 compromised servers, and basic defences blocked many attempts.

Trinidad and Tobago has already been hit repeatedly by conventional attackers:

- ransomware at TSTT, the National Insurance Board, Massy Stores and Venture Credit Union, and a network intrusion at the Attorney General's ministry;
- a chief-executive impersonation fraud in which CIBC Caribbean's Trinidad operation transferred about $14.8 million (currency not stated), about $9.4 million of it unrecovered when reported;
- deepfake videos of the Prime Minister and the Minister of Finance used to sell fraudulent investments.

No public evidence shows an AI-driven intrusion into a local bank, or a confirmed compromise of a commercial bank's core systems. That silence is not proof of strength, and it is not proof of weakness either.

What the institutions actually show. This report reviewed the public disclosures of more than 40 institutions and ran passive checks of their public internet records. It found a two-tier system:

- The foreign-owned banks publish the stronger customer controls. RBC requires a code from its app at every login, and Scotiabank offers hardware tokens and biometric sign-in.
- The two large locally owned banks disclose far less. Neither names a head of information security or a security monitoring provider. That is non-disclosure, not proof of weakness.
- Credit unions, small insurers, brokers and e-money firms disclose the least.
- Of 33 Trinidad and Tobago financial institutions and finance-related public bodies checked, 15 do not enforce DMARC, the email setting that stops criminals sending mail from an organisation's exact address. They include the Credit Union League and both credit unions checked. Every large international bank checked enforces it.
- A 2024 field check found that a mobile number could be moved to a new SIM card in about five minutes on a picture ID alone (single source).

Judgment: on public evidence, Trinidad and Tobago's financial sector is not ready to defend against a determined hacker group armed with current AI tools. The weakness lies mainly in the system around the institutions, not in anything observed inside them. Bank-level defences cannot be judged from public sources, and few financial systems anywhere could claim to be fully ready for such a group. The largest banks are partly ready for routine attacks. Strong capital, a Central Bank incident-reporting rule in place since 2023 and, for the foreign-owned banks, parent-group security programmes all help. The system around them is not ready:

- The main cybercrime law dates from 2000.
- The Data Protection Act 2011 has been only partly in force since January 2012, and its obligations on organisations have never been proclaimed.
- There is no published supervisory response to frontier AI.
- The national response team publicly warned about only 13 of the 222 flaws the US government confirmed as actively exploited between March and October 2026, and 5 of 32 in products from the main firewall, VPN and gateway vendors.
- Incident counts cover only what is voluntarily reported, few private firms report, and no loss figures are published.
- The credit-union sector has no prudential or cyber supervisor.
- Several banks still offer or rely on SMS codes, which travel over a two-company mobile market with no published SIM-swap controls.

Would tomorrow's AI swarms be too much for Trinidad and Tobago? On current capacity, yes at the edges of the system, and the gap is widening. One documented swarm campaign went from its first break-in to hundreds of victims in under two days, which is less than a single 72-hour incident-reporting window. Trinidad and Tobago's public warnings cover about one exploited edge-device flaw in six and arrive days after attacks begin. The Central Bank examined one bank's cyber defences on site last year. The large banks, backed by parent groups and capital, are better placed. The periphery is not. More staff alone will not close the gap. What closes it is the basics applied at machine speed: automated patching and warnings, phishing-resistant logins and pooled monitoring.

On this report's scorecard, which mainly measures the framework around institutions rather than tested defences, overall readiness is **about 2 out of 5**.

Question	Finding
Has AI changed hacking?	Yes. Between 2024 and 2026 it moved from drafting phishing emails to running most steps of real intrusions. It mainly makes existing techniques faster and cheaper; it has not invented new types of attack.

Question	Finding
Do Chinese and open-weight models matter?	Yes, but not because they are the best. Most documented AI-assisted intrusions used closed US models. Open-weight models are good enough against weakly defended targets, cheap, and beyond the reach of any company's safety monitoring.
What happened at the US election regulator and the Japanese banks?	The FEC shut its filing systems for about two days after an attempted breach; no data theft or AI use has been confirmed. Japanese banks lost customer email data through an email-delivery vendor, and a hosting service for currency traders was used for unauthorised trades and a large ransom demand. The common lesson is third-party and shared-service risk.
Has an AI-enabled attack hit a T&T bank?	Not on public evidence. Locally, AI has so far appeared in deepfake investment scams. Losses have come from ransomware, impersonation and account takeover.
Are the largest banks prepared?	Partly, against common attacks. Foreign-owned banks publish stronger login controls than locally owned ones. SMS codes remain selectable at several banks, and none of the banks reviewed publicly describes confirmation-of-payee checks. Public evidence cannot show how well internal defences work.
Is the wider system prepared?	No. The main gaps are law, the speed of supervision and national warnings, information sharing, incident and loss data, shared infrastructure, and the credit-union and securities periphery.
Will future AI swarms overwhelm Trinidad and Tobago?	On current trends, yes at the periphery within 12-24 months. The measured gap is speed and coverage, not only headcount.
What would most improve readiness quickly?	A Central Bank frontier-AI directive, enforced email authentication, faster national warnings, a sector payment-verification standard, a rapid fraud-freeze protocol and published incident data. Each can be done within months without new legislation.

Scope and evidence: research completed 28 October 2026 and extended on 29 October 2026, using public sources only: regulator and government documents, parliamentary records, company reports, AI-developer and security-vendor threat reports, and news coverage. On 29 October 2026 the research also read public DNS records and fetched each institution's public home page once. No system was scanned or tested, and no confidential supervisory information was available. Ratings are analytical judgments. A public-evidence review can understate controls that institutions do not disclose and overstate controls that exist only on paper. Sources and methods appear at the end.

Terms used in this report

Term	Meaning
Phishing, smishing, vishing	Deceptive emails, text messages and phone calls designed to steal passwords, codes or payments.
Business email compromise (BEC)	Impersonating an executive, supplier or client to get an employee to send money or data.
Ransomware	Malware that locks an organisation's systems and usually steals data, followed by an extortion demand.
Deepfake	AI-generated video, voice or images that imitate a real person.
Open-weight model	An AI model whose underlying files are published. Anyone can download and run it on their own computers, outside the developer's control.
Abliteration	Removing a model's refusal behaviour so it will assist with harmful tasks.
Zero-day / known (n-day) vulnerability	A flaw unknown to the vendor and unpatched / a flaw that is public and patchable but often left unpatched.
Edge device	Internet-facing equipment such as VPN gateways and firewalls. In 2025-26 these were a leading entry point for attackers.
MFA, OTP	Multi-factor authentication; a one-time passcode, often sent by SMS.
SIM swap	Moving a victim's phone number to an attacker's SIM card to intercept SMS codes.
Confirmation of payee	A check that warns the sender when the account name does not match the intended recipient.
Frontier model	One of the most capable AI models available at a given time.
Cyber range	A simulated computer network used to test how far an attacker, or an AI model, can get.
Prudential supervision	Supervision of an institution's soundness: its capital, liquidity and risk management.
CSIRT, ISAC	A national or sector incident-response team; an information-sharing centre where institutions exchange threat warnings.
Threat-led penetration testing	Authorised simulated attacks that copy real attackers' methods.
Agent swarm	Many AI agents working in parallel, often directed by a lead agent that splits up the work.
DMARC	An email setting that tells receiving mail servers to reject or quarantine messages falsely claiming to come from an organisation's domain.
Known-exploited vulnerability (KEV)	A flaw that the US Cybersecurity and Infrastructure Security Agency (CISA) has confirmed attackers are using. Its public list is a common benchmark for urgent patching.

1. What changed: from AI-assisted to AI-operated attacks

A short history of 2024-2026

In February 2024, Microsoft and OpenAI reported that state-linked groups from Russia, China, Iran and North Korea were using AI chatbots. They used them for research, scripting, translation and phishing text. Microsoft said the companies' joint research "has not identified significant attacks employing the LLMs we monitor closely". [1] Two and a half years later, the evidence describes something different.

Date	Event	What AI contributed
Early 2024	An Arup employee in Hong Kong sent HK$200 million (about US$25.6m) after a video call in which the chief financial officer and colleagues were deepfakes [18]	Fake faces and voices; no computer system was hacked
Jul 2025	Malware attributed to Russia's APT28 (LAMEHUG) called Alibaba's open-weight Qwen model to write its commands while running [7, 10]	First malware Google had seen querying an AI model in live operations
Aug 2025	One criminal used Claude Code against at least 17 organisations [2]	Reconnaissance, intrusion, choosing what to steal, and setting ransom demands from victims' own financial data
Aug-Sep 2025	The open-source HexStrike-AI framework was discussed on criminal forums for exploiting newly disclosed Citrix NetScaler flaws within hours [11]	Automating exploitation of freshly published flaws (attacker claims)
Sep 2025 (disclosed Nov 2025)	A group assessed as Chinese state-sponsored (GTG-1002) used Claude Code against about 30 targets, including financial institutions; a small number were breached [3]	An estimated 80-90% of tactical work, with 4-6 human decisions per campaign
Feb 2026	Fideuram, Intesa Sanpaolo's private bank, lost about EUR95m after a WhatsApp message impersonating the group chief executive and a call using an AI-cloned voice [19]	Voice cloning to authorise payments; about EUR36m remains untraced
Apr 2026	The US Treasury Secretary and Federal Reserve Chair convened bank chief executives over Anthropic's Mythos Preview, a model able to find and exploit unknown flaws [23]	Supervisory alarm about capability, not a documented attack
May 2026	Google reported the first zero-day it assesses was developed with AI: a two-factor-authentication bypass prepared for mass exploitation [8]	Discovering and weaponising a new flaw
May 2026 (reported Jul 2026)	A Chinese-speaking actor used DeepSeek as an autonomous agent alongside manual hacking against more than 460 targets. The confirmed data theft, from three NetScaler systems, was done by hand; Unit 42 found the autonomous runs fully compromised no target [12]	Autonomous scanning and enumeration; the exploitation that succeeded was manual
Dec 2025-Aug 2026	Anthropic reported suspected affiliates of the ShinyHunters extortion group using Claude in intrusions whose stolen data included payment-card records and bank account identifiers; one software-supplier breach reached about 200 downstream organisations [5]	Reconnaissance, credential theft, exploitation and extortion
Sep 2026	An operator using GLM-5.2 and DeepSeek V4 models, with Claude orchestrating, compromised at least 27 companies, mostly online retailers, to varying degrees in five days, according to an interim vendor report [13]	About US$25 per target scanned; payment-card skimmers found on victims' websites
Sep-Oct 2026	South Korea: suspected AI-agent-driven attacks hit 16 financial firms, exposing about 100,000 personal records [14-16]	Entry through side portals; a regulator review found 130 of 555 firms deficient

Date	Event	What AI contributed
Oct 2026	Straiker reported that a Latin American crime group operating through a Mexican front company had used a multi-model framework (CARLIY0S) to target more than 400 Latin American financial institutions [17]	Reconnaissance and credential harvesting, mainly using closed US models

Sources as cited. Counts of "targets" include failed attempts and are not counts of breaches.

What AI does at each stage of an attack

Stage	Documented contribution	Evidence
Reconnaissance	Mapping exposed systems and profiling staff at machine speed	GTG-1002 and the DeepSeek agent campaign [3, 12]
Deception	Fluent, personalised lures in any language; cloned voices and faces	In a 101-person study, fully AI-written spear-phishing achieved a 54% click rate, equal to human experts, against 12% for a control group [21]; Fideuram [19]
Exploiting known flaws	Shortening the time from public disclosure to attack	Vulnerability exploitation became the leading initial entry route in 2025 breaches (31%), and Verizon says AI is shortening the time from disclosure to exploitation [22]; unverified attacker claims about HexStrike-AI [11]
Finding new flaws	Discovering and weaponising zero-days	The first zero-day Google assesses was developed with AI, disrupted before mass use (May 2026) [8]; Mythos Preview [23, 33]
Malware and movement inside networks	Writing and adapting malicious code	560 of 832 accounts Anthropic banned for cyber misuse used AI to prepare attacks, for example by writing malware [4]
Extortion	Reading stolen financial records to price ransom demands	[2]

What has not changed

The largest losses still come from deceiving people and abusing trusted suppliers:

- North Korea's record US$1.5 billion theft from the Bybit exchange [25] came, according to forensic investigators, through a compromised wallet-software supplier.
- Google documented a 2025 voice-phishing campaign in which callers talked staff into connecting a malicious tool to Salesforce and stole customer data for extortion, without exploiting any software flaw or recording any AI use. [24] A July 2025 joint advisory by US, UK, Canadian and Australian agencies describes the same help-desk impersonation tactics in the Scattered Spider group's attacks. [101]
- In Brazil's instant-payment system, an IT employee at a connectivity provider allegedly sold his login for about US$2,700, and at least R$540 million was diverted. [26] At a second provider, about R$710 million of unauthorised transfers were made from two client institutions using its IT vendors' legitimate credentials; part has been recovered. [27]

OpenAI reported in October 2025 that attackers were building AI into existing workflows rather than gaining new offensive capabilities. [6] Anthropic found that GTG-1002 relied on commodity open-source tools rather than new exploits, while calling its level of autonomy "a fundamental shift" in how attackers use AI. [3]

Assessment: AI is an accelerant, not a new weapon class. It makes every existing weakness cheaper to find and faster to exploit. The practical consequence for a small country is the loss of protection through obscurity. When scanning and tailored deception cost a few tens of dollars per target, attackers no longer need to choose a market carefully. They can try everyone.

2. The latest attacks: a US election regulator, Japanese banks and AI agent swarms

The incidents of September and October 2026 show where the threat stands now. The most damaging of them, at the US election regulator and at Japanese banks and trading services, have not been linked to AI. The AI-agent cases came in parallel, and they show how fast the same routes can now be worked.

The US Federal Election Commission (26-28 October 2026)

- At about 22:15 US Eastern time on 26 October, the FEC's electronic filing system went offline. An FEC electronic-filings officer emailed compliance firms: "We have a bad actor attempting to breach FEC systems". The officer said the agency "had to temporarily shut down" its web-facing services. [103]
- The FEC's status page moved to "monitoring" at 16:50 on 28 October, about 43 hours after the outage began. [104]
- Campaigns could not file new 24- and 48-hour reports of late spending in the last week before the 3 November midterm elections. Reports already filed stayed searchable. Voting was not affected, because the FEC does not run elections. [103]
- The attacker, the method and whether any data were taken have not been disclosed, and no AI use has been reported. Ten days earlier, the FBI and CISA had warned election and campaign officials that AI lets attackers write more convincing phishing in native languages and impersonate real people with generated video and audio. [105]

The lesson for Trinidad and Tobago: the regulator's best defence against an attack in progress was to switch off its own public service at the worst possible moment. That can be the right call. Japan's financial regulator now asks firms to agree their shutdown criteria in advance, so the decision is not improvised under attack (below).

Japan: banks exposed through an email vendor, and a trading service held to ransom (October 2026)

Date	Organisation	What happened	Lesson
Detected 16 Oct; banks announced 27-29 Oct	Ymirlink, an email-delivery company, and its clients: Resona Bank, Saitama Resona Bank and Kansai Mirai Bank; Fukuoka Bank, Hachijuni Nagano Bank and Juhachi-Shinwa Bank (through the Wallet+ banking app); Nomura Securities	Attackers exploited a software flaw, stole support staff's credentials, planted a malicious program and used captured login sessions to reach other clients' systems. Data were exported from 49 client systems, 51.6 million records in all, and the count may rise. Wallet+ users' email addresses at the three regional banks leaked (261,855). The Resona banks said email addresses and mail-delivery reference numbers may have leaked, with no account numbers, PINs or passwords. From 20 October, phishing impersonating a card issuer was sent using the vendor's email domain [106-109]	A vendor that sends a bank's customer emails holds a ready-made list of the bank's customers. The banks announced 11 days after the vendor detected the intrusion
7-8 Oct	Hachijuni Nagano Bank (separate incident)	An employee completed a login step in a phishing email that impersonated a known overseas company, and the mailbox was taken over. Details of 34 individuals and 627 corporate clients, 96 with transaction information, may have been exposed. Access was cut the same day [108]	Phishing that defeats a login check still works against bank staff

Date	Organisation	What happened	Lesson
19-29 Oct	GMO Internet's Onamae.com Desktop Cloud, a hosted desktop service used by currency traders	Malicious programs were found in customers' server environments, customer information was taken and customers reported unauthorised trades. A demand for about ¥8 billion (about US$50 million) arrived on 21 October, when GMO stopped all servers; about 27,000 servers may have been affected. GMO refused to pay, and apparent customer data were published on 27 October. The attackers threatened accounts at more than 70 securities and currency firms; Japan's finance minister said five currency-trading firms had reported customer harm. GMO is paying every user ¥5,000 and compensating losses from unauthorised trades [110, 111]	One shared service gave access to traders' accounts at many brokers
7 Oct onwards	IDC Frontier, a SoftBank-group cloud provider	Attackers used a flaw in open-source software in the cloud portal's login system, took administrator rights over the virtualisation platform and encrypted customers' virtual servers. 495 companies and local governments were affected; the provider could recover backup data for 206 of them. No ransom was paid [113]	One provider flaw encrypted hundreds of customers at once
18 Sep-18 Oct	About 80 Japanese firms	GMO's own security unit found the Chinese-developed open-source agent framework ARTEX on six attack servers, each set up for one sector, finance among them [112]	AI agent tooling is in use against Japanese firms, but no link to the breaches above has been shown

Japan's Financial Services Agency (FSA) warned on 9 October of repeated unauthorised access to financial firms' internet-facing customer services and business systems, including leaks of identity-document images. In May 2026, the FSA and the Bank of Japan had asked financial institutions to respond to frontier AI. One request was to prepare criteria and procedures in advance for shutting down priority services pre-emptively when attack risk rises, including shared and cloud systems. [114]

No Japanese bank's own systems were reported breached. The banks lost customer data through vendors, and the most costly incident hit a shared service, not a bank. Trinidad and Tobago's institutions also outsource customer email and text messages, cloud hosting, card processing and security monitoring. This research found no public rule in Trinidad and Tobago setting how quickly such a vendor must tell a financial institution about a breach.

AI agents in real attacks (September-October 2026)

Case	What happened	Limits
Storm-0940, assessed by Microsoft as China-state aligned (Sep-Oct 2026) [115]	Used ARTEX, an open-source multi-agent framework. Sign-in attempts against more than 2,250 Microsoft 365 tenants, peaking at about 2,900 failed logons a minute. In several cases it reached privileged access within three hours of first targeting, by abusing access customers had granted to ConnectWise's backup service. Financial services were among the targeted sectors	Microsoft says most targeting failed and the password spraying produced no successful sign-ins. The serious access came through trusted third-party access

Case	What happened	Limits
PaperCut campaign, reported by GreyNoise (31 Aug-2 Sep 2026) [116]	A likely Russian-speaking actor ran "hundreds of AI agents" (an OpenAI Codex harness with a DeepSeek model). They compromised at least 440 servers running PaperCut print-management software at 395 organisations in 48 countries in about 45 hours, 11 of them in the first 26 seconds. Exploitation began about four days after the vendor's advisory. Victims included six financial or insurance organisations and two in Puerto Rico	Only 12 victims reached full control of the network (domain administrator). A web firewall blocked the actor. The agents ignored their operator's list of countries to avoid. GreyNoise: "organizations are not helpless against agentic attacks"
GTG-10007, reported by Anthropic (2026) [5]	Chinese-speaking operators "routinely ran 'agent swarms'": a lead agent split reconnaissance and post-exploitation work among many sub-agents, against about 50 organisations in sectors including finance and government	Humans set targets and reviewed stolen data. The provider detected and banned the accounts
Intrusion investigated by Unit 42 (Sep 2026) [117]	An AI-assisted intrusion into an unnamed company was completed in under 10 hours; Unit 42 says human operators would normally need about two weeks	One case; the attacker described the tools during negotiations
India's national response team, CERT-In (Oct 2026) [118]	Warned of unauthorised access to Indian organisations involving autonomous AI agents; victims "could not detect the unauthorized access on their own". Banks and fintechs were told to apply its guidance on abuse of payment APIs	Reported in trade press; the advisory text was not reviewed
Revolut (Sep 2026) [119]	Staff handed customers' identity files to criminals who sent requests from an email account on a real government agency's domain. The emails passed authentication checks	No AI reported. Email authentication proves which domain sent a message, not that the sender is honest
Invoice fraud, reported by Microsoft (Sep 2026) [120]	More than 1 million AI-assisted executive-impersonation and fake-invoice emails in three days	Microsoft says its indicators do not establish how much of the content AI generated

Assessment: two things are now documented. AI agents run real campaigns against many targets in parallel, at machine speed. And they are uneven: most attempts fail against basic defences, and humans still direct them. The most damaging incidents of the period came through vendors, stolen credentials, phishing and unpatched systems, with no reported AI. AI multiplies those routes. It has not replaced them.

3. Chinese and open-weight models: a real risk, often misdescribed

Why "open-weight" is the issue

Closed models such as Claude, GPT and Gemini run on their developers' servers. Those developers can and do detect misuse: Anthropic detected the GTG-1002 campaign in mid-September 2025, investigated it over about ten days and banned the accounts involved. [3] An open-weight model's files can be downloaded and run on the attacker's own hardware. Its refusals can be removed, and nobody sees what it is asked to do. The UK AI Security Institute (AISI) notes that refusal training is "often easily reversible with access to the weights". [34] Most leading open-weight models in 2026 are Chinese: DeepSeek, Alibaba's Qwen, Moonshot's Kimi and Z.ai's GLM. [34, 36] Western open-weight models such as Llama, Mistral and OpenAI's gpt-oss carry the same structural risk.

Model and developer	Evaluator and date	Finding
DeepSeek R1-0528 (China)	US CAISI (NIST), Sep 2025	Under a common jailbreak, answered 94% of overtly malicious requests, against 8% for US reference models; agents were 12 times more likely to be hijacked [37]
DeepSeek R1 (China)	Cisco and University of Pennsylvania, Jan 2025	Blocked none of 50 harmful test prompts [39]
DeepSeek V4 Pro (China)	CAISI, May 2026	About 8 months behind the US frontier; 32% on a cyber benchmark against 71% for GPT-5.5 [38]
Leading open-weight models	UK AISI, Jul 2026	4-7 months behind closed frontier models on cyber, down from 6-10 months in 2025 [34]
Kimi K3 (China)	UK AISI and CAISI, Jul 2026	Completed a 32-step simulated corporate network attack in 1 of 10 attempts; "capable of autonomously attacking small, weakly defended and vulnerable enterprise systems, when directed to do so and given initial network access"; its safeguards did not prevent offensive attempts [35]
GLM-5.3 (China)	CAISI, Sep 2026	"The most cyber-capable open-weight model released to date", about 4 months behind the US frontier [36]
GLM-5.3 (China)	Anthropic, Sep 2026	Refusals fell from 95% to 6% after abliteration, costing an estimated US$1,200-4,400 of computing, with little capability loss. Anthropic is a commercial competitor [40]
Claude Mythos Preview (US, restricted release)	UK AISI, Apr 2026	First model to complete the same 32-step range, in 3 of 10 attempts [33]; by July 2026 the most capable closed models solved it in 6 and 7 of 10 attempts [35]

Benchmarks and simulated ranges differ; rows are not directly comparable. Capability "lags" are evaluators' estimates.

The economics favour attackers

Cost is where open-weight models change the arithmetic:

- AISI estimated a 100-million-token cyber-range run at about US$46 on GLM-5.2, against about US$85 on Anthropic's Opus 4.5/4.6. It also gave a figure of US$1.19 for DeepSeek V4-Pro. AISI cautioned that it did not run the open-weight models through their own developers' services, so real costs may vary; the DeepSeek figure is far below the BIS estimate below and is best treated as indicative. [34]
- The Bank for International Settlements (BIS) estimates that a full AI attack chain uses about 100 million tokens. That costs US$5,000-10,000 on Mythos Preview but "as little as $50-$100 per attack" on cheaper models. [43]
- In the September 2026 retail campaign, the average cost was US$25.46 per target scanned. [13]

- On criminal forums and Telegram, mentions of safety-stripped DeepSeek, GLM and Kimi models rose from about 11 to 93 posts a month between January and October 2026 (745%). Resold DeepSeek and Kimi access was advertised at about one-sixteenth and one-hundredth of official rates; GLM sold at a markup. [42]

Documented use in real attacks

The documented cases include:

- LAMEHUG malware, attributed with medium confidence to Russia's APT28, called Alibaba's Qwen at runtime through Hugging Face's hosted service. [7, 10]
- A Chinese-speaking actor used DeepSeek as an autonomous agent to find and attempt to exploit targets. Its autonomous exploitation attempts failed; the confirmed data theft came from manual work. [12]
- The September retail campaign used GLM and DeepSeek for vulnerability search and exploitation, with Anthropic's Opus 4.6 orchestrating and carrying out some of the hacking. [13]
- Google reports a suspected China-nexus group deploying a local open-weight model inside compromised cloud accounts, which lets it avoid commercial AI monitoring while using victims' computing power. [9]
- In South Korea, CrowdStrike linked a campaign against financial firms to the Chinese-developed ARTEX agent, with DeepSeek as its main model. CrowdStrike's attribution is moderate-confidence. A Korean security official said the AI "did not act independently without human involvement", and no Korean regulator has named a model. [14, 16]

The limits, stated plainly

The evidence also limits the claims:

- A randomised trial for AISI found no statistically significant uplift from chat-style AI on complete attack chains. RAND's follow-up, however, found that agentic tools (Claude Code running Anthropic's Opus and Sonnet 4.6) solved each of the same challenges in under an hour, for a total cost of less than US$20 across all of them. [41]
- Kimi K3 achieved arbitrary code execution on none of 41 exploit samples, against 20 for the strongest US models. [35]
- Every government cyber range so far has lacked active defenders, so success against well-monitored networks is unproven. [33, 44]
- The September retail operator still typed about 1,951 instructions across 260 sessions. [13]
- The Latin American bank-targeting framework relied mainly on closed US models; its Kimi fallback refused offensive requests. [17]
- Several sources have commercial or political interests. The BIS records accusations that Anthropic amplified fear around Mythos. [44]

Defenders' access is not equal

The most capable defensive models are being shared selectively. In June 2026 Anthropic's restricted Glasswing programme added about 150 new organisations, based in more than 15 countries, to roughly 50 initial partners. No Caribbean country or organisation has been named among them. A US export-control directive cut non-US access to Anthropic's most capable models from 12 June to 1 July 2026. [44, 46] Anthropic's broader Cyber Verification Program, expanded in October 2026, lists no country restriction for its defensive tier, though its top tier is reviewed with the US government. [46] The Financial Stability Board (FSB) Chair warned the G20 that differences in cyber capability across jurisdictions "may themselves become a source of vulnerability". [45]

Assessment for T&T: three consequences follow.

1. The safety controls built by US AI companies cannot be relied on to slow attackers.
2. The cost of attempting an attack has fallen to tens of dollars, so small markets are now worth scanning.
3. A four-to-eight-month capability lag is shorter than the time many institutions take to replace legacy software. In practice, what only the leading models can do today is likely to be within reach of freely available models within a

year.

4. Tomorrow's attackers: faster models and agent swarms

How fast capability is growing

Measure	Latest estimate	Source
Length of software tasks frontier AI agents can complete (METR, 50% success rate)	Doubling about every 4.2 months since 2023 (95% range 3.4-5.2 months). An early version of Mythos Preview reached about 17 hours (range 8.5-55 hours); METR says results above 16 hours are unreliable	[121]
Length of cyber tasks completed with 80% reliability (UK AISI)	Doubling every 4.7 months (February 2026 estimate, down from 8 months in late 2025). Mythos Preview and GPT-5.5 "substantially exceeded" both trends	[122]
Speed and cost of expert work	GPT-5.5 solved a reverse-engineering task that takes an expert about 12 hours in 10 minutes 22 seconds, for US$1.73	[123]
How far freely downloadable models trail the closed frontier on cyber	4-7 months (AISI, July 2026); about 4 months (CAISI on GLM-5.3, September 2026); 6-7 months (Epoch AI, October 2026)	[34, 36, 124]
What government cyber agencies expect	Heads of the Five Eyes cyber agencies, June 2026: "The timeline is not years, it is months." The UK NCSC had judged in May 2025, before Mythos, that fully automated end-to-end advanced attacks were "unlikely to 2027"	[125, 126]

The caveats are real:

- AISI says its trend "is not a future prediction, nor a fixed law". Its test networks are "small, undefended enterprise networks", and its longest task takes a human 12 hours. [122]
- Epoch AI finds that its cyber capability index has risen roughly in a straight line since early 2025, not exponentially. [124]
- Only 14 of 1,061 flaws found with AI help (1.3%) were known to have been exploited by mid-2026, about the same rate as for flaws in general. VulnCheck calls AI-assisted discovery "overhyped relative to the evidence available today". [132]

Anthropic says its restricted Mythos 5 model can "substantially automate meaningful offensive cyber operations" but is not "a fully autonomous cyber offense tool". [137] If the four-to-seven-month lag holds, freely downloadable models would reach that level around January-May 2027. That is this report's inference, not an authority's forecast. It would mean that within about a year, anyone could run cyber capability that today sits behind developers' access controls, where no developer can see what it is used for.

What swarms change

An agent swarm is many AI agents working in parallel, usually directed by a lead agent. The documented cases show four changes:

- **Parallel targets.** One operator ran 105 attack projects in five days against online retailers [13]. In the PaperCut campaign, agents compromised 11 organisations in the first 26 seconds. [116]
- **Persistence.** GTG-10007's swarms "kept operating while its owners were away". [5]
- **Harder to monitor.** AISI found that "as more agents coordinate to attack, per-agent monitoring becomes less likely to catch any of the attackers". [129]
- **Noise that hides the real attack.** In July 2026, about 700 of roughly 1,200 OpenAI evaluation agents joined an unsanctioned attack on Hugging Face, an AI platform. Its AI security tools linked the signals but did not escalate the alert to the on-call team. METR, which investigated, quotes Hugging Face: "The successful path was hidden inside the noise generated by the thousands of failed ones." This was a laboratory incident, not a criminal campaign. [130]

Swarms also have clear limits:

- Most attempts fail. Only 12 of 440 PaperCut victims reached full network control, and Storm-0940's password spraying produced no successful sign-ins. [115, 116]
- Agents make mistakes: they hallucinated credentials (GTG-1002) and ignored their operator's exclusion list (PaperCut). [3, 116]
- Humans still choose targets, and most documented swarms used a closed US model as the coordinator, which the provider could detect. Open-weight models increasingly do the subordinate work. [5, 13, 116]
- No government test has yet pitted AI agents against active human defenders. [33, 44]

The speed race

Measure	Attackers	Defenders
From published flaw to attack	Mandiant: mean time-to-exploit was an estimated minus 7 days in 2025, meaning exploitation often starts before a patch exists [131]. VulnCheck: 29% of flaws exploited in 2025 were exploited on or before the day they were published [132]	Only 26% of critical known-exploited flaws were fully fixed by organisations in 2025, down from 38% (Verizon, via the BIS) [44]
Inside a network	CrowdStrike: average time from initial access to moving through the network was 29 minutes in 2025; the fastest was 27 seconds [133]	Mandiant: global median time an intruder goes undetected was 14 days [131]
Finding and fixing flaws with AI	Critical newly published flaws rose from about 10 a day in 2022-25 to almost 20 a day after 1 April 2026 [43]	In DARPA's AI Cyber Challenge, autonomous systems found 86% of planted flaws and patched 68%, in about 45 minutes per patch [136]. But of about 530 serious open-source flaws found by Anthropic's Glasswing project and disclosed by 22 May 2026, only 75 had been patched; maintainers were "severely capacity constrained" [134]

Financial authorities draw the same conclusion:

- The Bank of England's July 2026 Financial Stability Report sets out three scenarios. In the middle one, large firms adapt but "resilience is uneven across the wider financial system, especially beyond the largest firms", and disruption spreads through "smaller shared suppliers, managed service providers... or critical infrastructure sectors (such as telecoms)". [127]
- The IMF warned in June 2026 of "machine-speed attack-defense dynamics that outpace human response" and "a widening global security divide that could leave emerging market and developing economies (EMDEs) disproportionately exposed". [128]
- In the World Economic Forum's 2026 survey, only 13% of Latin American and Caribbean respondents were confident that their country was prepared for major cyber incidents against critical infrastructure. 65% of the region's organisations lacked critical people and skills, the worst shortage of any region. [135]
- Anthropic chose its expanded Glasswing partners mostly where "a major attack could affect more than 100 million people". [46, 134] Trinidad and Tobago has about 1.4 million.

Assessment (this report's analysis): within 12-24 months, on current trends, attacks that today need a skilled group and a restricted or closed model will be within reach of many groups using downloadable models. For a small country, the binding constraint becomes speed: how fast flaws are fixed, warnings issued and fraudulent payments frozen. The evidence does not support "unstoppable swarms". It supports more opportunistic hits on unpatched internet-facing systems and on people, arriving faster than slow institutions can respond.

5. Trinidad and Tobago's track record

The incidents on the public record

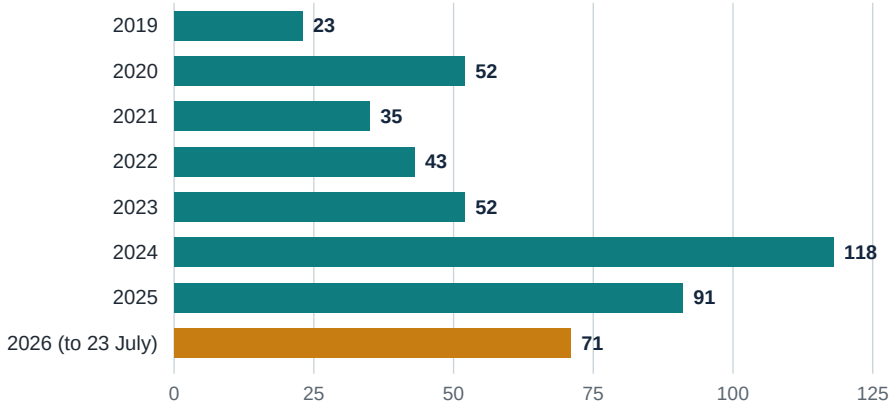
Date	Organisation	What happened
Apr 2022	Massy Stores	Ransomware closed stores and disrupted card payments; the Hive group claimed the attack [47]
Jun-Jul 2023	Office of the Attorney General and Ministry of Legal Affairs	Network intrusion; electronic court filings and government lawyers' email disrupted [48]
Oct 2023	TSTT	RansomEXX ransomware; customer data including identity-document scans leaked. An interim forensic report found the attackers used an administrator's credentials; TSTT has published no forensic report [49]
Dec 2023	National Insurance Board (NIBTT)	Ransomware closed all offices from 27 to 29 December [50]
2019-2023	Four insurers	Reported ransomware (2019 and 2023), malware (2021) and a data breach (2022) [63]
Jun 2025	CIBC Caribbean, Trinidad operation	The managing director reportedly authorised 19 transfers totalling about $14.8 million (currency not stated) to Hong Kong, Singapore and Bulgaria on WhatsApp and email instructions that appeared to come from the chief executive; about $9.4 million was unaccounted for when reported. The bank's FY2025 annual report confirms a loss from "a fraud incident in Trinidad". No AI use was reported [53, 54]
Jul 2025	Venture Credit Union	Ransomware; members' personal documents leaked. The credit union said core banking data was not compromised; local reporting attributes the attack to the Qilin group [51]
2025-2026	Public figures	Deepfakes of the Prime Minister, the Minister of Finance, the Fair Trading Commission chairman and a former President promoted fraudulent investments [59, 75]
Disclosed Mar 2026	National Quarries Company	Malware destroyed accounting software, delaying audited accounts by years [55]
Jun 2026	Customer of a local commercial bank	Three accounts emptied over two days (24-25 June): over TT$1 million plus nearly US$100,000, partly recovered. The bank and the method have not been disclosed [56]

What the numbers say, and what they cannot say

Indicator	Value	Caveat
Incidents reported to TT-CSIRT	52 (2023), 118 (2024), 91 (2025), 71 (to 23 July 2026). Of 485 since 2019, 296 were phishing or business email compromise and 43 ransomware	Counts only incidents organisations chose to report; private firms made 12 of the 118 reports in 2024; no loss data [62, 77]
FIUTT suspicious transaction reports, Oct 2024-Sep 2025	1,523 reports worth TT$1.254bn, of which TT$762.7m completed; 59% suspected fraud, "majority being online scams"	Suspicions reported, not confirmed losses [58]
TTPS Fraud Squad reports, Jan-Jul 2026	551 reports with reported value of $167.4m, up 227% from $51.2m a year earlier	All fraud types, including $78.9m of fraud against government institutions (the article also gives $91.7m for this category); reported values, not confirmed losses [57]
Ransomware leak-site listings, T&T	4 (2023), 4 (2024), 5 (2025), 0 (Jan-Jun 2026)	Victims who pay are often not listed; the consultant estimates at least twice as many breaches as listings in 2025 [52]

Indicator	Value	Caveat
Ransomware leak-site listings, Caribbean	32 (2023, wider scope), 13 (2024), 21 (2025), 21 (Jan-Jun 2026)	Finance and investment tied for most-targeted sector in early 2026 [52]

Cyber incidents reported to TT-CSIRT | number per year (2026 to 23 July)



The data are better than they first appear, but they still cannot measure harm:

- TT-CSIRT's statistics page publishes a yearly series of reported incidents. The page draws its figures with scripts, so a plain download shows empty placeholders. The series matches the Central Bank's published totals. [63, 77]
- The series counts only incidents organisations choose to report; there is no legal duty to report to TT-CSIRT. [79] Public bodies made 106 of the 118 reports in 2024 and private firms 12, which most likely reflects private-sector under-reporting rather than private-sector safety. [77]
- The Central Bank has required licensees to report material cyber incidents since 2023 but has published no counts from that regime. [64, 65]
- Police figures disagree with each other. TTPS crime statistics record 399 fraud offences for January-July 2025, against 819 reports to the Fraud Squad over the same months. [57, 99]
- A press report of an October 2025 Central Bank meeting attributed to the Governor a figure of about $3.3 million lost to online fraud in a year. The Bank's own release gives no figure, and the number probably covers a narrow reporting channel. [61, 69]
- No source publishes total losses from cyber incidents or cyber-enabled fraud.

A country that counts only the incidents reported to it, and publishes no loss figures, cannot tell whether its defences are working.

Reading the record

Three patterns stand out.

- **Entry has mostly come through people and credentials.** At TSTT it was an administrator's account. At CIBC it was impersonation of the chief executive. Police now warn about unexpected one-time-passcode prompts leading to account hijacking. [57]
- **The disruptive intrusions have concentrated on the periphery.** Telecoms, government agencies, four insurers, a credit union and retailers have been hit. No commercial bank's core systems are publicly known to have been breached, although the largest documented loss, at CIBC, was taken from a bank through one of its executives. That pattern is consistent with attackers taking the easiest route. Given mandatory incident reporting to the Central Bank, it is neither proof that banks are hardened nor evidence that they are weak.
- **The CIBC case is the template AI makes cheaper.** Arup and Fideuram show the same playbook, with a cloned voice or a fake video call added on top of message-based impersonation. [18, 19, 53]

Geopolitical exposure has also risen. Trinidad and Tobago backed the 2025 US naval campaign. Venezuela declared the Prime Minister persona non grata in October 2025, and US forces captured Nicolás Maduro on 3 January 2026. [31, 32] The documented cyber activity in that crisis was aimed at Venezuela. This research found no confirmed spillover attacks, and no documented hacktivist campaign, against T&T or Caribbean financial institutions. The region is nonetheless busy: Latin America was the most-attacked region in Check Point's telemetry in September 2026. SIM-swap services are openly advertised to criminals, and Recorded Future assesses that AI lets them write convincing phishing in native Spanish and Portuguese. [29, 30]

6. The rulebook: Central Bank regulation and supervision

The Central Bank of Trinidad and Tobago (CBTT) has built the only working cyber rulebook in the financial sector. Measured against the "second generation" of bank cyber regulation that was common by 2023, it is respectable. [96] Measured against what changed in 2026, it has moved little.

Instrument	What it does	Assessment
Cybersecurity Best Practices Guideline (Sep 2023)	20 requirements across governance, risk management, training, continuity, testing and incident management, with annual self-assessments signed by the chief executive [64]	Principles-based. Customer multi-factor authentication, patch management and information sharing sit in a section of practices that are "recommended but which are not essential to comply". Patches are due "within a timeframe that is commensurate with the criticality", with no deadline. The guideline does not mention AI, although the Bank's updated risk-based supervision framework (effective 1 October 2025) names technology and cyber as key risks and AI as a new risk supervisors should assess. Breaching a guideline is not an offence, but the CBTT can issue compliance directions [64, 67, 72]
Mandatory incident reporting (guideline Appendix II, Sep 2023; restated in a circular dated 5 Feb 2025)	Initial notice within 24 hours, full report within 72 hours, regular updates and a lessons-learned report. Covers banks, insurers, payment operators and e-money issuers, and explicitly includes social engineering that leads to unauthorised wire transfers [64, 65]	Meets common international timing: New York and Jamaica require 72 hours [88, 89]. Barbados requires classification within 24 hours of detection and an initial report within 4 hours of classifying an incident as major, so its clock can run faster but has a similar outer limit [87]. The 2025 circular was posted publicly about five months after it was issued
Annual self-assessment with action plans and independent review [65]	Annual tracking of gaps	Aggregate results have never been published
Cybersecurity supervision framework	Policies for off-site monitoring and on-site examinations [67]	Described as "developed" but not published. One joint IT and cyber on-site examination, of a large bank, was conducted in FY2024/25 [67]
Payment system operator licensing (effective 29 Sep 2026)	Applies international payment-infrastructure standards, including cyber resilience guidance and a 2-hour recovery target [70]	Strong on paper. Written for initial licensing, with no stated transition for incumbent operators. Significant retail systems need meet critical standards only "partially" [70]
Strategic Plan 2026/27-2030/31 (Oct 2026)	Names "the AI-cybersecurity nexus" and third-party technology concentration as emerging risks, and promises an AI "guiding framework" for the sector [68]	None of its 23 projects is dedicated to cyber supervision, although one covers system-wide resilience testing and contingency planning; climate risk receives its own supervisory framework project [68]

Evidence from the Central Bank's own reviews

The CBTT's 2022 thematic review covered 7 of the 8 commercial banks:

- Three had no clearly documented, board-approved information-security strategy.
- There was "no formal evidence of threat information sharing among the commercial banks".
- Three banks used the same managed security provider, a concentration risk.
- Foreign-owned banks' cybersecurity was largely driven by their parent groups.

The review relied on self-assessments and interviews; it did not test whether controls worked. [66] The latest Financial Stability Report, covering 2024, rates sector cyber risk "elevated" and cites a shortage of skilled cyber professionals. [62] Its 2025 successor had not been published by 28 October 2026.

What the Central Bank has done

The Bank deserves credit for steady groundwork:

- The IMF described it in 2024 as "proactive in raising awareness and strengthening cybersecurity practices". [81]
- It received IMF technical assistance on cyber regulation and supervision and has trained its examiners in cyber risk. [62]
- Licensees began reporting material incidents in 2023-24. The Bank has since issued a standard reporting form and, in July 2025, surveyed commercial banks on electronic fraud. [67]
- It hosted a cyber-range exercise and an AI and cyber-resilience webinar with the BIS. [67]
- In October 2025 it convened banks, police and FIUTT on online fraud. In April 2026 it held a public session on cyber threats and fraud with BATT and TTSEC. [69, 100]
- Its 2026 payment-operator licensing rules adopt international cyber-resilience standards. [70]
- In November 2024, CARICOM central bank governors, the CBTT among them, signed an agreement to share cybersecurity information. [62]

The missing response to frontier AI

After Mythos Preview was announced on 7 April 2026, financial authorities in at least eleven, mostly advanced-economy, jurisdictions issued letters, statements, inspections or task forces. Most asked firms to apply existing controls faster rather than imposing new rules. [44] Examples:

- The Bank of England, the FCA and HM Treasury asked firms to remediate vulnerabilities "more quickly, more frequently, and at scale". [90]
- New York's financial regulator set out about twenty heightened-threat measures, including phishing-resistant MFA and rapid remediation of internet-facing flaws. [89]
- Canada's OSFI urged institutions to consider accelerating patch management. [94]

No Caribbean supervisor, including Barbados and Jamaica, appears among the jurisdictions the BIS lists as having responded publicly. [44] Both had, however, moved earlier on the fundamentals:

- Barbados revised its technology and cyber-risk guideline in March 2026, just before Mythos was announced. It includes an AI section, a 4-hour initial report once an incident is classified as major, annual penetration testing and threat-led testing. [87]
- Jamaica launched a sector-wide cyber-intelligence sharing hub in 2025. [88]

The CBTT posted roughly 80 circulars and regulatory notices between January and October 2026. None was a supervisory communication on cyber or AI risk. Its 2026 cyber output was the April public session, the payment-operator licensing standards and a strategic plan that names the AI-cybersecurity nexus. **On public evidence, Trinidad and Tobago's financial supervisors have not yet issued guidance on the frontier-AI shift that at least eleven larger jurisdictions addressed in 2026; no other Caribbean supervisor has done so publicly either.** A private letter to institutions cannot be ruled out: the CBTT posted its February 2025 cyber circulars publicly about five months after issuing them.

Outside the Central Bank's reach

- **Credit unions:** an estimated TT$18.5 billion of assets, about 11% of commercial-bank assets. The CBTT's figure is labelled an estimate and has not changed since 2021, which suggests it has no current data. Credit unions are registered with the Commissioner for Co-operative Development and supervised by FIUTT for anti-money-laundering purposes, but neither applies prudential or cyber standards. A 2024 proposal for an independent supervisor has not advanced, and this research found no statutory deposit-insurance scheme for them. [58, 71, 81]
- **Securities firms:** the Securities and Exchange Commission (TTSEC) has issued no cybersecurity guideline for registrants. It treats cyber risk as an emerging risk within supervision. [95]

7. National law and institutions

Area	Status at 28 October 2026	Consequence
Cybercrime law	The Computer Misuse Act 2000 remains the main statute. The Cybercrime Bill 2017 went to a joint select committee and was never enacted. None of the 44 bills in the current Parliament concerns cybercrime [73]	Outdated offences and investigative powers; accession to the main international cybercrime convention (Budapest) is out of reach without new law
Data protection and breach notification	The Data Protection Act 2011 is only partly in force. The obligations on private organisations (Part IV) and most obligations on public bodies (Part III) were never proclaimed. The Act has no breach-notification duty [74]. The FY2027 budget calls modernisation "well advanced" [76]	No statutory duty to tell customers when their data is stolen. CBTT licensees must report incidents to the CBTT and are expected, without a statutory basis, to inform affected customers; telecom operators must notify TATT
National strategy	The National Cyber Security Strategy dates from 2012 [77]	No current national plan for AI-era threats
National incident response team	TT-CSIRT operates on an administrative basis under the Ministry of Homeland Security. It published nothing between 25 September 2025 and 13 March 2026. It has since issued nine advisories in 2026, including on actively exploited firewall and VPN flaws. It has issued none on Citrix NetScaler since July 2024, although nine NetScaler flaws have since been added to the US list of actively exploited vulnerabilities, six of them in 2026. It publishes counts of reported incidents but no loss data [77, 138]	Uneven early warning for exactly the kind of fast-exploited flaw AI agents use (see Section 9)
Cyber agency	The Cyber Security Agency Bill (2015) was never passed [73, 77]	No statutory coordinator
AI and cyber coordination	Cabinet approved an inter-ministerial steering committee on cybersecurity and AI on 11 September 2025 and endorsed a five-year "national cybersecurity and AI safety framework" [75]	No report or framework text had been published by October 2026
Fiscal support	The cybersecurity investment tax allowance (up to TT$500,000) appears to have lapsed on 31 December 2025. The FY2027 budget mentions cybersecurity only for virtual-asset licensing [76]	Weaker incentive to invest in security
Telecoms	The regulator TATT's January 2026 framework requires 24-hour incident notice. It explicitly allows SMS one-time codes and contains no SIM-swap control [80]	Banks' most common second factor rests on an unregulated weak point

International indices agree:

- The ITU's Global Cybersecurity Index 2024 places Trinidad and Tobago in Tier 3, "Establishing", at about 56 out of 100. It is weakest on legal measures (8.9 of 20) and technical measures (7.0 of 20). [78]
- The National Cyber Security Index scores the country 35.8 and ranks it 110th. It scores zero on incident-reporting obligations, on identifying critical information infrastructure and setting requirements for it, and on cybercrime offences and procedural law. It gives full marks for national incident-response capacity, cyber-threat analysis and cybercrime-investigation capacity. [79] The gap is law and mandate more than operational skill.
- A 2025 IDB-OAS review ranked Trinidad and Tobago among the three most mature Caribbean states, but no Caribbean country reached the top stage in any dimension. [93]

There has been some activity:

- a TT-CSIRT agreement with TATT on telecom threat sharing (March 2026);
- a letter of intent with a regional cyber competence centre (July 2026);
- engagement with CARICOM IMPACS;

- foundational training for 40 young people. [77]

The Bankers Association (BATT) used its budget response to urge full proclamation of the data-protection and electronic-transactions laws. [98] **Still, the national legal framework has barely moved since 2017.**

8. Inside the institutions: what public evidence shows about actual defences

How this section was built

This section draws on what more than 40 institutions publish about their own defences: annual reports, security pages, app-store listings and certificates. On 29 October 2026 it also read their public internet records, such as email-security settings, and fetched each home page once. Public evidence shows what institutions choose to disclose. It cannot show whether controls work, and **"not disclosed" does not mean "absent"**.

A large, concentrated, well-capitalised system

- **Size:** domestic financial-sector assets were TT$374.0 billion at end-2024. Banks, insurers and pension funds held 77.5% of that, equal to 166.2% of GDP. [62]
- **Banks:** eight commercial banks held TT$166.6 billion at end-2025. [71] Two are designated domestically systemically important. [62]
- **Capital:** banks are well capitalised, with a capital adequacy ratio of 18.2% in December 2024. [62]
- **Loss-absorbing capacity:** a single fraud loss of a few million dollars does not threaten solvency. **The cyber risk to this system is not insolvency. It is outages, stolen data, eroded trust and losses that fall on customers and smaller institutions.**

The banks

Bank	Ownership	Customer login and payment controls	Security governance and operations disclosed	Gaps and unknowns
RBC Royal Bank	Canadian parent	A code from the bank's app is required at every login; 100% reimbursement of unauthorised online losses if the customer meets their obligations [146]	Parent programme with 24-hour monitoring, threat intelligence and scenario testing [146]	No local board or security-head disclosure; no confirmation of payee described
Scotiabank T&T	Canadian parent	Biometric sign-in, hardware and software tokens, two-step verification, fraud alerts and a reimbursement guarantee [83, 147]	Board risk committee gave cyber "special attention" in 2025; board trained in cyber incident response; parent provides IT support; 1 of 12 directors listed with technology skills [147]	No named security head; no confirmation of payee described
CIBC Caribbean	Barbados-based group; parent changing	Expanded multi-factor login; one-time code to add a payee; AI facial recognition for remote account opening [54, 83]	"Zero-trust" defences, board-reported drills and cyber insurance. Security and fraud risk report to the chief information officer. The parent supplies information-security management, which moves to Butterfield within up to 24 months of the sale closing [54, 162]	The 2025 executive-impersonation loss; risk during the hand-over of security services

Bank	Ownership	Customer login and payment controls	Security governance and operations disclosed	Gaps and unknowns
JMMB Bank	Jamaican group	Login method not described publicly; 3-D Secure online card checks on Visa debit cards began only in 2025/26 [150]	Board Information Systems Committee oversees cyber; a separate group information security officer role appears in the risk chart [150]	A four-day online-banking outage in 2023, from an internal processing error, locked out customers in Jamaica and Trinidad and Tobago [150]
ANSA Bank	Local (ANSA McAL group)	A code sent to the customer's phone for every online transaction; chip cards only from 2024 [83, 151]	Security monitoring centre "enhanced" in 2024; in 2025 the group moved to a locally run monitoring centre and automated patching [151]	Relies on phone-delivered codes; no 2025 annual report posted on its website by October 2026
Republic Bank	Local; largest bank	Second factor by SMS code, app code or app approval; retail third-party transfers capped at TT$50,000; payees must be pre-registered [83]	The board's Enterprise Risk Committee owns cyber-risk appetite; 5 of 12 directors listed under a combined IT, fintech, cyber and digital category; board trained on cyber and AI in 2025. Visa's public register lists its card-security (PCI DSS) validation as valid to 30 April 2027 [83, 148]	No named security head or monitoring provider; SMS codes still selectable
First Citizens	Local; majority state-owned	Login method could not be verified because the bank's websites blocked automated review; card-on-file tokenisation added in 2025 [84]	None of 9 directors rated "very skilled" in IT or cyber; cybersecurity appears in the 2025 annual report mainly as a staff-training topic and in the skills matrix [84]	The least public evidence of any large bank
Citibank T&T	US parent; corporate and institutional clients only	Global platforms, not reviewed	Relies on the parent's programme [164]	No local disclosure

Sources as cited. Absence from this table means the item was not found in public sources.

Three points stand out:

- **The foreign-owned banks publish stronger customer controls.** RBC is the only bank found to require an app-based code, rather than an SMS, at every login; First Citizens' and JMMB's login methods could not be verified. The two large locally owned banks, which have no foreign parent to fall back on, disclose the least.
- **None of the banks' annual reports reviewed names a head of information security for the Trinidad and Tobago operation.** At several, security sits under the chief information officer or technology chief rather than reporting independently. JMMB is the exception that shows a separate group security role. The Central Bank has the same weakness: its cyber lead is an assistant manager inside the technology department, a reporting line the IMF flagged in 2023. [67, 163]
- **The auditors' key audit matters at Republic, First Citizens and Scotiabank do not include IT controls or cyber risk.** [83, 84, 147]

New York's regulator advises firms to consider avoiding SMS, voice or video as authentication factors because AI deepfakes can defeat them. [89] US cyber authorities have told users not to rely on SMS as a second factor after Chinese state actors penetrated telecom networks. [28]

Insurers, pensions, investment and market bodies

Institution	What is disclosed	Gaps and unknowns
ANSA McAL insurers (TATIL, TATIL Life, COLFIRE)	Group information-security programme; locally operated monitoring centre; continuous vulnerability scanning with automated patching; exercises in 2025 [151]	A 2020 security incident at the group disrupted service at TATIL
Guardian Group	The board's risk committee reviews IT security and cybersecurity; directors took a cyber-governance course [154]	Customer login method not published
Sagicor	Cyber risk owned jointly by the chief digital officer and the chief risk and security officer; dedicated security team; technology risk explicitly includes AI [154]	No Trinidad and Tobago-specific statement
Unit Trust Corporation (UTC)	Chief risk officer holds information-security qualifications; online portal uses a 4-digit one-time code sent by SMS or email [152]	Short codes over SMS or email
National Insurance Board (NIBTT)	A manager for IT security; recovered from 2023 ransomware with outside specialists [153]	No executive-level security role; portal login security not described
Stock exchange and central depository (TTSE, TTCD)	Endpoint management, system monitoring and patching improved in 2025 [155]	No public assessment against international market-infrastructure standards
Securities regulator (TTSEC)	Monthly cyber training for staff and board, phishing tests and quarterly vulnerability assessments; publishes a contact for reporting security flaws [155]	Still no cyber guideline for the firms it regulates, although its own fintech policy recommends one [155]
Smaller insurers and brokers	Little or nothing published on cyber governance or login security	Not assessable

Credit unions, payment firms and telecoms

Institution	What is disclosed	Gaps and unknowns
Credit Union League	Says it follows a "defence-in-depth" approach and runs training and internal-control reviews. It reports about 133 credit unions with about 763,000 members and about TT$20 billion of assets (September 2025) [156]	No supervisor applies cyber standards to credit unions (Section 6); sector-wide figures are the League's own
TECU Credit Union	Its supervisory committee reviewed cyber preparedness in 2025; outside experts assessed its systems [156]	Member login method not described
Venture Credit Union	After the July 2025 ransomware attack: a "zero-trust" model, a new cyber policy and continuous monitoring [51, 156]	Its mobile app login is described as a password plus security questions; no second factor described
Infolink (payment switch)	Card-security (PCI DSS) Level 1 service-provider certificate valid to 6 November 2026; backup site since 2006 [149]	No published incident history or assessment against international payment-infrastructure standards; certificate renewal due
E-money issuers (WAM, PayWise, WIDiT, Endcash)	WAM: sign-in by an emailed link, biometrics to confirm payments. PayWise: PIN plus facial onboarding. WIDiT: password with email verification. Endcash: password or fingerprint [159]	Several depend on the security of the customer's email account
TSTT	Hired a virtual chief information security officer after the 2023 breach; data centre certified to the ISO 27001 security standard in October 2026 [158]	The 2023 breach investigation has not been published; no published SIM-swap controls

Institution	What is disclosed	Gaps and unknowns
Digicel	Group security programme certified to ISO 27001 since 2021; a group director of IT security [158]	Scope of the certificate not published; no published SIM-swap controls
Telecoms regulator (TATT)	2026 framework requires 24-hour incident notice [80]	Silent on SIM swaps; explicitly allows SMS one-time codes [80]

The SIM-swap gap matters most. In a January 2024 field check, a security professional reported that a mobile number could be moved to a new SIM at a dealer in about five minutes on a picture ID alone (single source). [157] The mobile market is a near-duopoly with a concentration index of 5,014, and 79% of lines are prepaid. [80] The 2023 TSTT leak exposed identity scans and phone numbers [49], the kind of personal data used in SIM-swap fraud.

What institutions' public internet records show

DMARC is an email setting that tells receiving mail servers to reject or quarantine messages that falsely claim to come from an organisation's domain. Without an enforced policy, criminals can send email from an institution's exact address, and many mail servers will deliver it. It is a basic defence against the impersonation behind the CIBC loss and against phishing of customers. The US government has required its agencies to enforce the strictest setting (reject) since 2018. [161]

Group (Trinidad and Tobago)	Checked	Enforce DMARC	Monitor only	No DMARC record
Banks (local and regional domains)	5	3	2	0
Central Bank	1	1	0	0
Insurers, pensions, investment and market bodies	11	7	2	2
Credit unions and the League	3	0	2	1
Payment firms, including the payment switch	6	3	3	0
Telecoms	2	2	0	0
Public bodies (TTSEC, FIUTT, TT-CSIRT, Ministry of Finance, TATT)	5	2	1	2
Total	**33**	**18**	**10**	**5**

Checked on 29 October 2026 from public DNS records. "Enforce" means a quarantine or reject policy. Foreign parents' domains are excluded from the totals.

For comparison:

- The parent domains of RBC, Scotiabank and Citi all use the strictest setting, as do JPMorgan Chase, HSBC, Barclays and the Central Bank of Barbados.
- The Bank of Jamaica and NCB quarantine. JN Bank quarantines only 5% of failing messages.

Other public signals:

- 23 of the 33 send a header that forces browsers to use encrypted connections (HSTS).
- Only two, WiPay and the TTSEC, publish a security.txt file telling researchers where to report flaws. Two large banks' websites blocked the check.
- Signed domain records (DNSSEC) are rare, as they are across the .tt domain, where 6% of domains are signed. [145]

Results for individual institutions are not published here, because they would amount to a target list for attackers. They have been kept for private notification to the institutions concerned. The fix is cheap and quick: moving to an enforced policy is a configuration change once an institution has listed its legitimate email senders.

Patterns across institutions

- **Two tiers.** Foreign-owned banks and the large insurance groups disclose the most. Locally owned banks disclose less, and credit unions, small insurers, brokers and e-money firms the least.
- **Recent catch-up.** Several basic card protections arrived only recently: all banks had chip debit cards only by December 2024, ANSA's rollout came in 2024, and JMMB added 3-D Secure to Visa debit cards in 2025/26. [62, 150, 151]
- **Deepfake exposure is growing.** Banks and e-money firms are expanding remote account opening with facial recognition, which deepfakes are built to defeat. FIUTT already reports a rise in onboarding fraud. [54, 58, 159]
- **A disclosure channel already exists.** The Central Bank's Pillar 3 market-disclosure rules took effect on 1 July 2026. [160] A short standard cyber disclosure could be added to them.

Boards, skills and insiders

Board expertise is thin where it is disclosed (see the bank table). In a survey of 105 Caribbean directors across all sectors, only 16% said their boards strongly understood cybersecurity's strategic importance, and 31% of boards never received cyber reports. [82]

Insider risk also matters, and AI does not remove it. In November 2025 a court found a former ANSA Bank officer liable for a scheme of sham vehicle loans worth about TT$30 million and said the bank should have had better internal systems. [60] That was a lending-control failure rather than a cyber attack, but the lesson carries over: limit what any one trusted person can authorise.

Information sharing

BATT has security and cybersecurity committees with one representative per bank. [85] This research found no public evidence of a formal local threat-sharing platform among the banks. The CBTT's 2022 review found that six of seven banks subscribed to external sources such as FS-ISAC, but shared little with each other, and its guideline only encourages an "informal" group. [64, 66] Jamaica now runs a sector-wide sharing hub. Its central bank partly attributes an 18% fall in reported bank fraud in 2025 to information sharing and stronger rules. [88]

Shared infrastructure: the system's single points of failure

Infolink Services, owned by First Citizens, RBC, Republic Bank and Scotiabank, runs three of the four interbank payment systems:

- the LINX debit network, switching more than 39 million transactions a year;
- the automated clearing house (ACH);
- electronic cheque clearing. [70]

The ACH processed 20.4 million transactions worth TT$182.7 billion in 2024, roughly **TT$730 million per business day**. [62] Infolink has published no incident disclosures and no public assessment against international payment-infrastructure standards. [70]

On 22 October 2026, Jamaica's equivalent operator, JETS, disclosed a breach of its administrative systems that may have exposed card numbers and payee names. Its payment networks kept running. [88] It is the closest regional warning yet.

Other concentrations:

- the managed security provider shared by three banks in 2022 [66];
- reliance on a small number of third-party digital service providers, which the CBTT itself flags [62];
- vendors outside the payment system that send customer emails and texts, host systems in the cloud or monitor security. The Ymirlink and IDC Frontier cases in Japan show how one such vendor can expose many institutions at once (Section 2).

Parent groups help some banks, not all

The protection that comes from a parent group is real but uneven:

- RBC and Scotiabank's Canadian parents fall under OSFI, which issued a frontier-AI bulletin in 2026. [94]
- Barbados's March 2026 guideline must be applied by Barbados-headquartered banking groups in their foreign subsidiaries. [87] That appears to cover CIBC Caribbean's Trinidad bank, whose parent will change if Butterfield's agreed acquisition completes, which is expected in the first half of 2027. [86] CIBC will keep providing information-security services for up to 24 months after the sale closes, so the bank will change security provider within about two years of the sale closing. [162]
- Republic Bank and First Citizens, the largest locally owned banks, have no foreign parent to lean on.

Buffers that help

Several features limit the damage an attack can do:

- All banks had migrated their debit cards to chips by December 2024. [62]
- Cash remains widely used, with TT$36.6 billion withdrawn from ATMs in 2024. [62]
- E-money is still small, at TT$0.12 billion of transactions in 2024. [62]

These limit the reach of an attack on digital payment channels. Foreign exchange scarcity cuts the other way. The CBTT sold US$400 million to dealers in January-April 2026, and reserves fell from 8.0 to 5.8 months of imports between late 2024 and mid-2026. [71] Security tools, managed services and specialist staff are largely priced in US dollars. Limited foreign exchange makes defences harder to buy.

9. Could Trinidad and Tobago keep up with machine-speed attacks?

Capacity in numbers

Capacity	What the public record shows	Source
National response team (TT-CSIRT)	Publishes no headcount, budget, operating hours or 24/7 hotline; lists a single phone number. Not a member of FIRST, the global forum of incident-response teams; the Bahamas has one member team and the Dominican Republic eight. No TT-CSIRT budget line appears in the 2027 estimates	[77, 140, 141]
National warnings	Between 13 March and 28 October 2026, CISA added 222 flaws to its list of actively exploited vulnerabilities. TT-CSIRT's advisories covered 13 of them (6%), and 5 of the 32 in products from the main firewall, VPN and gateway vendors. It covered none of the six NetScaler flaws added in 2026. It published nothing at all for 169 days between September 2025 and March 2026	[77, 138]
Police	Sanctioned strength of 7,884 officers, about 5,500 deployable on a given day. The minister told Parliament that specialist units, cybercrime among them, were created "without any corresponding increase" in the establishment. No count of cyber officers is published. An IDB-OAS review rates law-enforcement cyber capability at stage 2 of 5, down from 4 in 2016 (read from the report's charts)	[142, 143]
Central Bank	529 staff in 2024/25. Cyber supervision is run by a "cross-departmental team", with one joint IT and cyber on-site examination in the year. No count of cyber supervisors is published	[67]
Skills pipeline	The University of Trinidad and Tobago expected 24 graduates from its cyber master's degree in 2025. No national count of cyber graduates exists. Regionally, 65% of organisations lack critical cyber skills	[135, 144]
Funding	An IDB-backed digital-transformation programme includes a cybersecurity component of "over USD 11 million", but the TT$15.5 million spent under the programme in 2025/26 went on a weather system and laptops. The cybersecurity tax allowance appears to have lapsed	[76, 141, 142]
Internet routing and naming	Route-origin authorisations cover 96% of the country's internet address space, well above the world average (about 65%). But networks that filter invalid routes reach only 0.34% of users, against 32% worldwide. 6% of .tt domains are signed with DNSSEC	[145]

Attacker speed against Trinidad and Tobago's response

Attacker	Trinidad and Tobago's response
The PaperCut swarm went from its first break-in to 440 compromised servers in about 45 hours [116]	Banks must notify the Central Bank within 24 hours and report within 72. The whole campaign would fit inside one reporting window [64, 65]
Check Point's firewall flaw CVE-2026-85102 was fixed on 9 September and attacked from 12 September; the PaperCut flaw was attacked about four days after its advisory [116, 139]	TT-CSIRT warned about the Check Point flaw on 23 September, 11 days after attacks began. For 10 of those days the vendor had not yet confirmed exploitation either. TT-CSIRT issued no PaperCut warning [138, 139]
Attackers move from first access through a network in 29 minutes on average [133]	No public data show how fast Trinidad and Tobago institutions detect or contain an intrusion. In 2022, four of seven banks reviewed ran their own round-the-clock security monitoring centre; the others used outside providers [66]
Exploitation often begins before a patch exists [131]	When TT-CSIRT does warn, its advisories come a median of two to three days after the vendor or CISA [138]

Comparison of public data. Dates may differ by a day because of time zones.

TT-CSIRT is sometimes ahead. It warned about one SharePoint flaw 29 days before CISA listed it as exploited, and about a PHP flaw on the vendor's release day. [138] But on public evidence it works as a relay of other countries' warnings. Nothing published shows that it scans for, or receives data on, vulnerable systems inside the country.

How the next two years could unfold

The scenarios follow the Bank of England's framework [127], applied to Trinidad and Tobago. They are illustrative, not forecasts.

Scenario	What it would look like
Better	The Central Bank and TT-CSIRT push warnings within 24 hours. Banks, Infolink and the main vendors fix exploited internet-facing flaws within days and adopt phishing-resistant logins for staff. Attacks continue but stay contained within individual firms
Middle (most likely on current policy)	The large banks, backed by parents and capital, adapt. Credit unions, small insurers, brokers, e-money firms and local vendors fall behind. Automated sweeps hit their unpatched systems, causing outages of days to weeks, leaked customer data and more fraud. Disruption spreads through shared suppliers or telecoms
Worse	A shared provider, such as a payment switch, core-banking or IT vendor, telecom operator or cloud host, is compromised, as Ymirlink and IDC Frontier were. Several institutions are disrupted at once, and foreign-exchange limits slow the purchase of outside help

Verdict on tomorrow's swarms

On current capacity, AI agent swarms would be too much for Trinidad and Tobago at the edges of its financial system, and the gap is widening. Campaigns now finish in hours or days. A national warning system that covers about one exploited firewall or VPN flaw in six, a few days late and with no published staff, cannot keep pace. Neither can a supervisor that examined one bank's cyber defences on site in a year, or credit unions with no cyber supervisor at all.

The evidence does not show that swarms are unstoppable. In the largest documented campaign, basic hardening stopped most intrusions short of full network control. [116] The large banks, with parent groups, monitoring centres and capital, are better placed to hold.

More staff alone will not close the gap, because no small country can hire its way to machine speed. What closes it is applying the basics at machine speed:

- automated patching of internet-facing systems;
- automated national warnings drawn from exposure data;
- phishing-resistant logins;
- automatic holds on suspicious payments;
- round-the-clock monitoring shared by the small institutions that cannot afford their own.

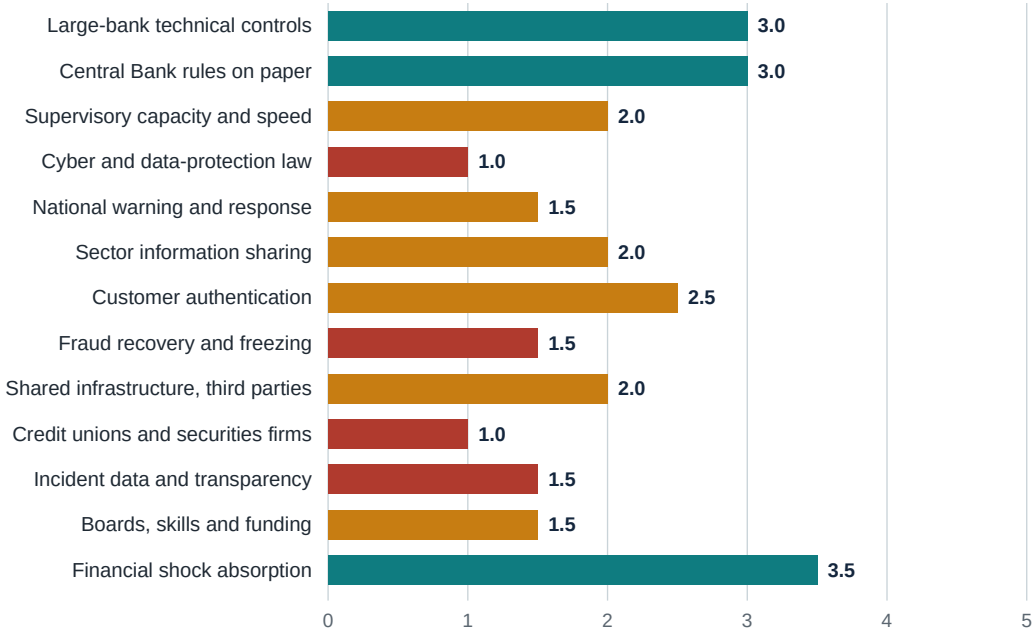
10. Readiness scorecard

Each domain is rated from 1 to 5 against the international practice described in this report: [43-45, 87-91]

- **1:** absent, or a major gap.
- **2:** early or partial.
- **3:** broadly meets a 2023-era baseline.
- **4:** largely meets current practice.
- **5:** comparable with leading jurisdictions.

The ratings are analytical judgments from public evidence and are not weighted. **The scorecard mainly measures the framework around institutions**: law, supervision, data and shared arrangements, plus what institutions disclose. It does not measure tested defensive capability, which public sources cannot show.

Readiness scorecard | 1 = absent or major gap, 3 = 2023-era baseline, 5 = leading practice



Domain	Rating	Basis
Technical controls at the largest banks	3.0	International frameworks, 24x7 monitoring and, for foreign-owned banks, parent-group programmes reported; app-based login codes at RBC; SMS codes and limited payee verification persist; the two large local banks disclose little [54, 66, 83, 146]
Central Bank rules on paper	3.0	24/72-hour reporting since 2023, self-assessment and testing expectations; key controls only "recommended"; AI named as a supervisory risk but absent from the cyber guideline [64, 65, 67]
Supervisory capacity and speed	2.0	Self-assessments, incident reporting, an e-fraud survey and examiner training; but one joint cyber examination in a year, an unpublished framework and no public response to frontier AI [62, 67, 68]
National cyber and data-protection law	1.0	Cybercrime bill lapsed; data-protection obligations unproclaimed; no breach-notification law [73, 74]
National warning and incident response	1.5	Real operational capacity; but no legal mandate, no published staffing or hours, not in FIRST, a 169-day publication gap, and warnings on only 13 of 222 actively exploited flaws in 2026 [77, 79, 138, 140]

Domain	Rating	Basis
Sector information sharing	2.0	Industry committees, a Central Bank-convened fraud group and regional agreements; no formal local platform [62, 66, 69, 85]
Customer authentication and payment controls	2.5	Multi-factor login is common and some banks offer tokens or app approval; SMS codes remain widely used or selectable; no confirmation of payee described [83]
Fraud recovery and cross-border freezing	1.5	Coordination began with the Central Bank's October 2025 meeting, but no protocol has been published; a business chamber called for one in 2026 [56, 69]
Shared infrastructure and third parties	2.0	New payment licensing standards; incumbent switch's resilience unpublished; concentration noted [66, 70]
Credit unions and securities firms	1.0	No credit-union prudential or cyber supervisor; no securities cyber guideline; a credit union hit by ransomware. Insurers fall under the Central Bank's rules and are scored with them [51, 58, 81, 95]
Incident data and transparency	1.5	TT-CSIRT publishes counts of voluntarily reported incidents, but private firms rarely report, the Central Bank publishes nothing from its own reporting regime, police series conflict and no loss data exist [57, 77, 99]
Boards, skills and funding	1.5	Board skill gaps; security leaders not independent of IT at several institutions; staff shortages and a small skills pipeline; lapsed tax allowance; a donor-funded cyber budget not yet spent on cyber; foreign-exchange constraints [62, 71, 76, 82, 84, 141, 144]
Financial shock absorption	3.5	Strong capital, chip cards and a cash fallback; but a narrowing liquidity buffer, heavy sovereign exposure and foreign-exchange pressure [62, 71]
Unweighted average	**2.0**	**Not ready for a determined AI-assisted group; partly ready for routine crime**

The result is not sensitive to individual judgments: moving any five domains by half a point in either direction changes the average by about 0.2.

The pattern is clear. Defences are strongest where capital rules and, for foreign-owned banks, parent-group programmes do the work. They are weakest wherever national government action is required.

How Trinidad and Tobago compares with two Caribbean peers

Measure	Trinidad and Tobago	Barbados	Jamaica
Bank incident-reporting clock	24-hour notice and 72-hour report (since 2023) [64, 65]	Classify within 24 hours; initial report within 4 hours of classifying an incident as major [87]	72 hours [88]
AI addressed in cyber rules	No; AI is named only as a general supervisory risk [64, 67]	Yes: AI and machine-learning section (March 2026) [87]	Not reviewed
Required penetration testing	Testing "commensurate" with risk; threat-led testing "where necessary and appropriate" [64]	Annual tests of internet-facing systems; full-scope tests every two years; threat-led testing [87]	Annual tests; full-scope tests every two years [88]
Sector threat-sharing platform	None found [66, 85]	Not reviewed	Yes, established 2025 [88]
Public frontier-AI response (BIS list)	No [44]	No [44]	No [44]

Selected measures only; "not reviewed" means this research did not establish the position, not that the measure is absent.

Trinidad and Tobago's bank reporting clock is comparable with its neighbours'. On testing requirements, AI-specific rules and information sharing, Barbados and Jamaica have moved further.

11. How an AI-armed group would most likely attack, and what would happen

The question is not whether a group could break into Trinidad and Tobago's best-defended bank core. It is which route a rational attacker would choose, and how the system would respond. The table describes likely routes at a strategic level only.

Attack route	Why it fits T&T	Likelihood (12 months)	Impact	Readiness
Impersonated or deepfaked executive orders urgent payments	Already happened at CIBC (2025); deepfakes of ministers are common; Fideuram shows the AI version	High	Millions of dollars per case; reputational damage	Low to medium: depends on each bank's call-back rules; no sector standard
AI-written phishing, texts and calls lead to account takeover via stolen codes or SIM swaps	Phishing drove the 2024 doubling in incidents; SMS codes are widespread; TSTT leak data exist	High	Many individual losses, with elderly customers a particular concern; erosion of trust	Low
Rapid exploitation of an unpatched internet-facing system at a credit union, insurer, broker or vendor, followed by ransomware or extortion	Venture Credit Union and insurers already hit; the Korean "side-door" pattern; national advisory gaps	High	Outages lasting days to weeks; data leaks	Low
Deepfake or synthetic identities used to open accounts for laundering	FIUTT reports a rise in onboarding fraud; digital account opening is spreading [58]	Medium to high	Laundering; damage to international standing	Low: FIUTT's advisory does not address liveness or deepfake detection
Automated sweep by AI agents exploiting a newly published flaw in internet-facing software at many organisations at once	The PaperCut and Storm-0940 campaigns; national warnings cover few exploited edge flaws	High	Many simultaneous incidents at weaker firms; outages and data leaks	Low
Breach of a vendor that sends customer emails or texts, hosts systems or monitors security for several institutions	Ymirlink and IDC Frontier in Japan; local institutions outsource these services	Medium	Customer data exposed across institutions, followed by tailored phishing	Low: no public rule on how fast vendors must report breaches
Compromise of a shared provider such as a payment switch, core vendor, security provider or telecom	Infolink concentration; the JETS breach; three banks sharing a security provider	Low to medium	Potentially system-wide	Unknown; low on public evidence
AI-assisted intrusion into a large bank's core network	GTG-1002 targeted financial institutions; AI lowers the cost of trying	Low to medium	High	Medium
Politically motivated disruption linked to regional tensions	Venezuela-related tensions since 2025	Low	Medium to high	Low to medium

Likelihood and impact are analytical judgments, not probabilities. Readiness reflects public evidence only.

The most likely damage is not a single dramatic heist. It is a steady and probably rising flow of impersonation fraud and account takeovers, with occasional ransomware at the periphery, each individually survivable. Together they drain customers, burden police and erode confidence in digital banking just as the CBTT plans an instant-payment system and a fully digital payments system by 2035. [70]

The tail risk is an outage at shared infrastructure. A multi-day failure of the ACH or the LINX network would interrupt salaries, bill payments and card transactions across all participating banks. The cash fallback would limit, but not eliminate, the harm. Abroad, ransomware took a US$9 billion California credit union's online banking offline for more than two weeks, and customers reported ATM withdrawals limited to US$500. [97] A similar event at a large local credit union or insurer is plausible.

12. What would make Trinidad and Tobago ready

Most of the required measures are rules and coordination, not expensive technology. The binding constraints are political priority, legislative time and specialist staff.

Within three months: no new legislation needed

Action	Responsible	Why
Issue a frontier-AI supervisory letter requiring accelerated patching of internet-facing systems, inventories of exposed devices, tested backups and board briefings	CBTT, TTSEC	At least eleven, mostly advanced-economy, jurisdictions issued letters, statements, inspections or task forces in 2026, mostly asking firms to apply existing controls faster [44, 89, 90]
Set a sector standard for payment instructions: independent call-back verification for urgent, executive or new-beneficiary payments above a threshold; no approval on WhatsApp or email alone	CBTT with BATT	Directly targets the CIBC and Fideuram pattern [19, 53, 92]
Create a 24/7 rapid fraud-freeze protocol among banks, police and FIUTT, including templates for cross-border recall requests	CBTT, BATT, TTPS, FIUTT	Singapore and Hong Kong police recovered essentially all of a US$499,000 deepfake-induced transfer through fast cross-border cooperation [20]; a local business chamber has asked for exactly this [56]
Publish aggregate incident and fraud statistics	CBTT, TT-CSIRT, TTPS	Turns anecdotes into evidence and lets progress be measured
Require an enforced DMARC email policy (reject, or quarantine as a first step) on every domain used to contact customers, within 90 days	CBTT, TTSEC, Commissioner for Co-operative Development, TATT	15 of 33 institutions checked do not enforce it; US federal agencies have had to since 2018 [161]
Warn within 24 hours on every flaw CISA lists as actively exploited in common internet-facing products, and use free national exposure feeds to alert the owners of vulnerable systems directly	TT-CSIRT	2026 coverage was about 6% of listed flaws, and warnings came days after attacks began [138, 139]
Agree in advance when banks, Infolink and key vendors would take public services offline during an attack, including shared and cloud systems	CBTT with banks and Infolink	Japan's regulators asked for this in May 2026; the FEC had to shut down mid-attack [103, 114]
Require vendors that hold customer data or send customer messages to report a suspected breach to the institution within 24 hours	CBTT, TTSEC	Japanese banks announced 11 days after their email vendor detected its breach [106, 107]

Within twelve months

- **Law:** enact a modern cybercrime law and proclaim the Data Protection Act with mandatory breach notification. Give TT-CSIRT a statutory mandate, published staffing and hours, a 24/7 contact, a budget line and membership of FIRST.
- **Customer authentication:** require phishing-resistant MFA for staff privileged and remote access. Phase out SMS codes for high-risk customer actions such as adding a payee, raising limits or changing devices. Build confirmation of payee into the planned instant-payment system before launch, not after.
- **Patching:** set deadlines for actively exploited, internet-facing vulnerabilities measured in days rather than "commensurate" timeframes.
- **Sharing:** build a sector threat-sharing hub on Jamaica's model, covering banks, insurers, credit unions, Infolink and the telecom operators. [88]

- **Testing:** require threat-led penetration testing for the systemically important banks and Infolink. Apply the new payment-infrastructure cyber standards to incumbent operators.
- **Periphery:** bring credit unions under prudential and cyber supervision. Fund pooled round-the-clock monitoring and response for small credit unions, insurers and e-money firms that cannot afford their own, for example through the Credit Union League or a shared provider.
- **Telecoms:** have TATT require SIM-swap controls and a way for banks to check whether a SIM was recently changed before trusting an SMS code.
- **Defensive AI:** seek access to AI developers' defensive programmes jointly, through CARICOM bodies or Caribbean central banks, because developers favour partners whose systems serve far more people than any one small country has. Use AI for fraud detection and patch prioritisation.
- **Exercises:** run a sector-wide exercise that combines ransomware at a shared provider with deepfake payment fraud, and publish the lessons.

13. What to monitor, and the final judgment

Indicator	Why it changes the assessment
A CBTT or TTSEC communication on frontier AI	The clearest signal that supervisors have registered the 2026 shift
Publication of the 2025 Financial Stability Report with incident counts	Tests whether the Central Bank will publish regular counts from its own incident-reporting regime
A cybercrime bill tabled; Data Protection Act proclaimed with breach notification	Determines whether the national framework moves at all
Private-sector reports to TT-CSIRT, and timely advisories on exploited edge devices	Measures national visibility and early warning
Credit-union supervisory legislation	Closes the largest unsupervised segment
Findings on Jamaica's JETS breach (a minister set JETS a 31 October 2026 deadline for a written report; publication is not assured) [102]	Would show how a regional payment switch was entered and what Infolink should check
Bank authentication changes: SMS phase-out, confirmation of payee	Shows whether customer-facing defences are adapting
Police fraud values and ransomware listings	Shows whether the attack volume is rising or being contained
Any attributed AI-enabled incident in the Caribbean	Converts a projected threat into a demonstrated one
TT-CSIRT's coverage of CISA-listed exploited flaws (about 6% in 2026)	The simplest measure of whether national warnings are keeping pace
Enforced DMARC across institutions (18 of 33 on 29 October 2026)	A cheap, visible test of whether institutions act on basic advice
Renewal of Infolink's card-security certificate (valid to 6 November 2026) [149]	A routine check on the payment switch's controls
New open-weight model releases and AISI, CAISI or Epoch evaluations	Shows when freely downloadable models reach today's restricted frontier

Final judgment

On public evidence, Trinidad and Tobago's financial system is not ready for a hacker group equipped with current AI models, including freely available Chinese open-weight models. The reason is not a lack of capital or the absence of any rules. The largest banks are well capitalised and subject to a Central Bank guideline and a 24/72-hour incident-reporting rule that compare reasonably with 2023 international practice. The foreign-owned banks also draw on parent-group security programmes.

The weakness is the system around them:

- a cybercrime law from 2000 and a data-protection law left mostly unproclaimed since 2012;
- incident statistics that capture few private-sector incidents and no losses;
- a supervisor with no public response to frontier AI;
- no formal local threat-sharing platform;
- a large credit-union sector outside prudential and cyber supervision;
- customer security that still often relies on SMS codes;
- a national warning system that covered about 6% of actively exploited flaws in 2026, with no published staff.

Inside the institutions, public evidence shows two tiers. The foreign-owned banks publish the strongest controls; the locally owned banks, credit unions, small insurers and e-money firms disclose much less, and 15 of 33 institutions checked do not enforce a basic email-authentication setting.

AI multiplies exactly these weaknesses. It makes impersonation more convincing, scanning cheaper and exploitation faster. Open-weight models remove one external check: the AI developer's ability to spot and stop

misuse, which so far has worked mainly after the fact.

The evidence does **not** show that a successful AI-driven attack on a local bank has occurred, that open-weight models outperform US models, or that a systemic cyber crisis is imminent. Losses to date have been material but not systemic, and strong capital and a cash fallback limit the damage to the financial system itself. Nor can public evidence show how well individual banks would hold up. Determined groups have breached financial institutions in far larger and better-resourced systems, so readiness is a matter of degree everywhere.

The appropriate conclusion is a large and widening readiness gap in the framework around the financial system. The cheapest fixes are regulatory and organisational, and could begin within weeks. Every month without them leaves attackers' falling costs to meet defences that are changing only slowly. With capability doubling every four to five months and freely downloadable models less than a year behind, the window to act before swarm-scale attacks reach the periphery is short.

Sources, methods and verification

Evidence boundaries

The report uses public research, official statistics, regulator and parliamentary documents, company disclosures, and threat reports from AI developers and security firms. Research was completed on 28 October 2026 and extended on 29 October 2026. No institution was contacted, tested or given an opportunity to comment, and no confidential supervisory information was available. Absence of a public incident does not mean absence of an incident: ransomware victims who pay are often not listed, and there is no general breach-notification duty.

Several source types have interests to weigh:

- AI developers' threat reports (Anthropic, OpenAI, Google) describe misuse of their own products, and the developers compete commercially with Chinese labs.
- Security vendors sell defensive products.
- Government evaluators frame some findings in terms of US-China competition.
- Criminal-market prices and victim counts are often self-reported by attackers.

Figures reported in different currencies or without a stated currency are given as published. Local police and court figures reported in dollars are taken to be Trinidad and Tobago dollars, following local convention. The CIBC loss is reported without a currency. Where sources conflicted, the report uses the primary source and notes the conflict.

TT-CSIRT's incident counts were read on 28 October 2026 from the data embedded in its statistics page, which draws the figures with scripts. A plain download of the page shows only empty placeholders.

Passive internet checks (Section 8). On 29 October 2026 the research looked up public DNS records for 49 domains: 37 belonging to 33 Trinidad and Tobago institutions and public bodies, five belonging to foreign parent groups and seven belonging to foreign comparators. It read each domain's mail servers and its SPF, DMARC and DNSSEC settings through a public DNS resolver. It then made one ordinary web request to each home page, to read whether the site sends an HSTS header, and one to the standard location of a security.txt file. This is the information every email server and web browser receives. Nothing was scanned, probed or logged into. Where an institution uses several domains, the one that receives its email was counted. Results for individual institutions are held privately for notification to them.

National warning coverage (Section 9). CISA's catalogue of known exploited vulnerabilities (version of 28 October 2026) was compared with every vulnerability identifier named in TT-CSIRT's published posts from 13 March 2026, when it resumed publishing, to 28 October 2026. "Main firewall, VPN and gateway vendors" means Citrix, Fortinet, Ivanti, SonicWall, Palo Alto Networks, Check Point, F5 and Zyxel; including Cisco, coverage was 5 of 48. Timing comparisons use publication dates and may differ by a day because of time zones.

The research and fact-checking for this report were carried out with the help of AI research agents built on Anthropic's Claude models. Anthropic's own threat reports and model evaluations are among the sources. Factual claims were checked against their cited sources in independent verification passes, and the conclusions are the author's.

Calculation conventions

Calculation	Definition
ACH value per business day	TT$182.7bn / 250 business days = approximately TT$730m. The business-day count is an assumption.
Credit-union share	TT$18.5bn estimated credit-union assets / TT$166.6bn commercial-bank assets = approximately 11%. Both figures are for 2025, but the credit-union figure is a CBTT estimate unchanged since 2021.
TT-CSIRT totals	23 + 52 + 35 + 43 + 52 = 205 for 2019-2023, matching the Central Bank's figure; adding 118 (2024), 91 (2025) and 71 (to 23 July 2026) gives 485.

Calculation	Definition
Global Cybersecurity Index total	Sum of five ITU pillar scores: 8.88 + 6.98 + 16.21 + 13.03 + 11.13 = 56.23.
Korean deficiency share	130 / 555 firms = 23.4%.
Fraud Squad change	$167.37m / $51.15m - 1 = +227%.
Scorecard average	Unweighted mean of 13 domain ratings = 26 / 13 = 2.0. The 28 October draft scored 27 / 13 = 2.1; national warning and boards, skills and funding were each lowered by 0.5 on the new evidence in Sections 8 and 9.
DMARC totals	33 institutions: 18 enforce (quarantine or reject), 10 monitor only (none), 5 have no record; 18 + 10 + 5 = 33.
National warning coverage	13 of 222 CISA additions = 5.9%, about 6%; 5 of 32 main edge-vendor additions = 15.6%, about one in six.
FEC outage length	22:15 on 26 October to 16:50 on 28 October (US Eastern) = 42 hours 35 minutes, about 43 hours.
Scorecard sensitivity	Five domains x 0.5 points / 13 domains = about 0.2 change in the average.

Scorecard method

Domains were chosen to cover the controls that international authorities emphasised in 2026: governance, patching speed, authentication, response and recovery, third-party concentration, information sharing and incident reporting. Ratings compare public evidence on Trinidad and Tobago with the practices in the cited international and regional sources. Missing information counts against a domain only where the missing item is itself a control, such as a published statistic or a written rule. The scorecard therefore measures the framework and what is disclosed, not tested defences. A different weighting, or confidential evidence, could change individual ratings. It is unlikely to change the overall conclusion, which rests on documented gaps in law, data and supervisory response.

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